

Challenge 2: Action-First Experience

What you will build

You will build a seamless transactional layer for an untapped niche — one that drastically reduces interaction costs for both users and businesses, turning static listings into instant, meaningful actions.

The goal is not to list businesses.

The goal is to enable action — and to make the platform the place where it happens.

Context

Today's typical flow looks like this:

| Search → listing → leave the platform → external action

Every time a user has to leave to complete what they came to do, value is lost. For users, it's friction. For businesses, it's a missed connection. For the platform, it's a dead end.

The irony is that directories already hold most of the relevant information. The business is there. The service is described. The need is clear. And yet the system stops exactly where the value should start.

This challenge is about closing that gap — not just visually, but structurally.

Your challenge

This challenge requires you to think in two modes simultaneously: as a product strategist and as a builder.

Step 1: Find your niche

Before you build anything, you need to identify where a transactional layer would create real value. This is not a technical exercise — it's a strategic one.

Look for service categories or interaction types where:

- Existing platforms are absent, fragmented, or broken

- The coordination between user and business involves unnecessary friction
- Both sides (user and business) would clearly benefit from a better interaction model
- A platform could realistically be adopted without requiring massive behavior change

Think carefully about unit economics. Why would a business actually use this? What do they gain — time, leads, reduced back-and-forth? And on the user side: what does "instant action" actually mean in this context?

We are not looking for obvious plays. If a well-funded platform already does this well, it's not a whitespace. The stronger your niche rationale, the stronger your solution.

Step 2: Reduce interaction cost

Once you have your niche, design the interaction with obsessive focus on friction removal. Fewer steps. Faster decisions. A clear and inevitable next action.

Map the current broken flow: where does it start, where does it break, where does the user give up? Then redesign it from there — not by optimizing individual steps, but by rethinking the journey as a whole.

From intention → to action → to outcome.

Step 3: Enable direct action within the directory

Build the mechanism that makes action possible: booking, request submission, scheduling, matching, or whatever form fits your niche. The key is that the action completes within the experience — not somewhere else.

This should integrate naturally with the directory context: listings become entry points, not dead ends.

What we are NOT looking for

If a solution for your chosen niche already exists and works well, building a version of it is not interesting to us — regardless of execution quality. The starting point of this challenge is finding a space where the answer doesn't exist yet, or where existing solutions have meaningful structural weaknesses. That research and rationale is part of what we evaluate.

Simple replicas of existing platforms — however well-built — will not be considered innovative. The most common trap here is building "X for Y" without asking whether X is actually broken in context Y, and whether the platform model is the right solution.

We are also not looking for UI-only concepts. The logic behind the interaction — how decisions are made, how users are guided, how actions are triggered — must be visible and functional.

Where to start

Think about real-world service experiences that feel broken:

- "I want to book this, but I have to call during office hours"
- "I submitted a request three days ago and heard nothing"
- "I don't even know how to start — do I call? Email? Fill out a form?"
- "I found the right business but I still have to figure out the next step myself"

Where does the journey actually break? Where should the platform take over?

Technical hints (optional)

- Workflow automation
- Matching logic
- Booking / scheduling systems
- Lightweight AI (optional, not required)

Focus on flow, not tech complexity.

Resources & Setup

Available data

- SMB dataset (as a starting point or reference)
- You are free to define your own niche and data structure

Optional environment

- Frontend mock (directory UI)
- Backend starter

Note: the current request/inquiry flow is documented in the repo as a process diagram. Use it to understand the baseline — and to see where the structural problems actually are.

Demo expectations

Show clearly:

1. The niche you chose — and why it's a real whitespace
2. The current broken flow — where does friction occur?
3. Your solution — how does the user move from intent to action?
4. The action itself — show the actual outcome: booking, request, match, scheduled interaction

We want to see a complete flow, not just an interface. Your system should demonstrate how decisions are made, how users are guided, and how action is triggered. The logic behind the UI must be visible.

Evaluation criteria

Criterion	Focus
Relevance	Is this a real problem in a real niche?
User value	Does it meaningfully reduce friction for the user?
Business value	Does it create clear value for the business side?
Innovation	Is the niche and approach genuinely new?
Execution	Does the flow actually work end-to-end?

One sentence

Turn static listings into instant, meaningful actions — in a space where no one has done it well yet.